
2.5 Learning approach

Students will be assessed on their ability to:

- 1 Definition of the approach**
 - a Define the learning approach showing understanding that this approach is about the effects of conditioning, reinforcement and social learning on the organism.
 - b Define and use psychological terminology appropriately and accurately including the terms:
 - i classical conditioning (including extinction, spontaneous recovery)
 - ii operant conditioning (including positive and negative reinforcement, primary and secondary reinforcement, punishment)
 - iii social learning (including imitation, modelling, observation, vicarious reinforcement)
 - iv stimulus and response.

2 Methodology/ How Science Works

- a Describe and evaluate observation as a research method in psychology.
- b Identify, describe and apply the terms participant, non-participant, overt, covert, naturalistic observations
- c With regard to inferential statistics, identify, describe and apply
 - i levels of measurement
 - ii reasons for choosing a chi-squared (χ^2) test, Spearman and Mann-Whitney
 - iii how to compare the observed and critical value(s) to judge significance

Note: with regard to inferential tests, no calculations will have to be carried out in the examinations and formulae do not have to be learnt.

- d Describe and evaluate the laboratory experiment method as it is used in general with human and with animal participants (including details specified for the Cognitive and Biological Approaches).
- e Describe and assess ethical guidelines for the use of human participants when carrying out psychological research (include details specified for the Social and Biological Approaches).

3 Content

- a Describe the main features of classical conditioning, including unconditioned stimulus (UCS), unconditioned response (UCR), conditioned stimulus (CS), conditioned response (CR), extinction and spontaneous recovery.
- b Describe the main features of operant conditioning, including positive and negative reinforcement, punishment, primary and secondary reinforcement.
- c For either classical or operant conditioning, describe and evaluate one treatment/therapy. Suitable examples: aversion therapy, systematic desensitisation, token economy programmes.
- d Describe the main features of social learning theory, including observation, imitation, modelling, vicarious reinforcement.
- e Describe how learning theory can be used to explain gender development/behaviour with particular reference to modelling, reinforcement and behaviour shaping.
- f Evaluate learning theory as an explanation of gender behaviour including comparison with explanations from the Biological and Psychodynamic Approaches.

4 Studies in detail

- a Describe and evaluate Bandura, Ross and Ross (1961) Transmission of aggression through imitation of aggressive models and **one other** study. This **must** be selected from the following:
 - Watson and Rayner (1920) Little Albert
 - Skinner B F (1948) Superstition in the pigeon
 - Pickens R, and Thompson T (1968) Cocaine-reinforced behavior in rats: effects of reinforcement magnitude and fixed-ratio size.

5 Key issue

- a Describe **one** key issue of relevance to today's society and apply concepts, theories and/or research (as appropriate) from the Learning Approach to explain the issue.

Suitable examples:

- the influence of advertising on people's behaviour
- the increase of female violence related to changing role models
- the influence of role models on anorexia.

Note: in the examination paper, students may be given stimulus material from a key issue to explain using concepts, theories and/or research (as appropriate) from the Learning Approach.

6 Evidence of practice: short observation

- a Carry out an observation using participants either from real life or using another medium such as television. This practical must be designed and conducted according to ethical principles.
- b The observation must focus on some aspect of learning theory (such as modelling or reinforcement) and must gather quantitative data (eg by using tallying) that leads to a chi-squared (χ^2) test.

Suitable examples:

- an observation of a nursery setting looking at the frequency of boys and girls' choice of gender-specific toys
- an observation of a television programme or similar media to record if positive reinforcement leads to the desired response more often than if there is no reward.

- c Analyse the findings to produce results including using the chi-squared (χ^2) test.

Note: with regard to inferential tests no calculations will have to be carried out in the examinations and formulae do not have to be learnt.

- d Apply issues of validity, reliability, generalisability and credibility to their results.

Methods

Note: students must be prepared to answer exam questions focused on practical work, which will include questions about the practical exercises themselves and questions about the general methodological issues that are specified for this particular unit. This will include the following requirements.

a Identify, describe and apply the following:

- i validity
- ii reliability
- iii generalisability
- iv credibility
- v overt/covert
- vi non participant /participant
- vii qualitative
- viii quantitative
- ix laboratory experiment
- x chi-squared (χ^2) test
- xi levels of measurement
- xii levels of significance
- xiii critical value and observed value
- xiv naturalistic observations
- xv ethical issues.